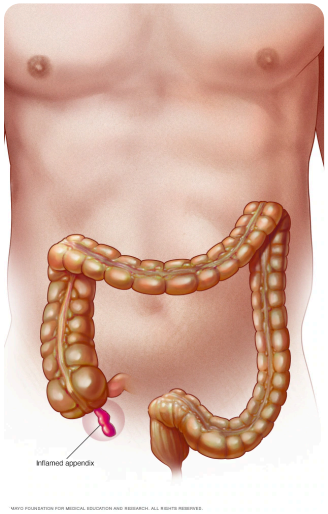
Appendicitis

Overview



Appendicitis

Enlarge image

Appendicitis is an inflammation of the appendix. The appendix is a finger-shaped pouch that sticks out from the colon on the lower right side of the belly, also called the abdomen.

Appendicitis causes pain in the lower right part of the belly. However, in most people, pain begins around the belly button and then moves. As inflammation worsens, appendicitis pain typically increases and eventually becomes serious.

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Although anyone can develop appendicitis, most often it happens in people between the ages of 10 and 30. Treatment of appendicitis is usually antibiotics and, in most instances, surgery to remove the appendix.

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Symptoms

Symptoms of appendicitis may include:

- Sudden pain that begins on the right side of the lower belly.
- Sudden pain that begins around the belly button and often shifts to the lower right belly.
- Pain that worsens with coughing, walking or making other jarring movements.
- Nausea and vomiting.
- Loss of appetite.
- Low-grade fever that may rise as the illness worsens.
- Constipation or diarrhea.
- Belly bloating.
- Gas.

The site of the pain may vary, depending on age and the position of the appendix. In pregnancy, the pain may seem to come from the upper belly because the appendix is higher during pregnancy.

When to see a doctor

Make an appointment with a healthcare professional if you or your child has symptoms. Terrible belly pain requires immediate medical attention.

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Causes

A blockage in the lining of the appendix, called the lumen, is the likely cause of appendicitis. This blockage can cause an infection. The bacteria then multiply quickly, causing the appendix to become inflamed, swollen and filled with pus. If not treated right away, the appendix may burst or break open.

Risk factors

Risk factors for appendicitis include:

- Age. Anyone can develop appendicitis, but it most often happens in people between the ages of 10 and 30.
- Your sex. Men have a slightly higher risk of appendicitis than do women.

Complications

Appendicitis may cause serious complications, such as:

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- **A burst appendix.** A burst appendix, also called ruptured appendix, spreads infection throughout the abdomen, a condition called peritonitis. Possibly life-threatening, this condition requires immediate surgery to remove the appendix and clean the abdominal cavity.
- **A pocket of pus that forms in the abdomen.** If the appendix bursts, a pocket of infection may develop. This is called an abscess. In most cases, a surgeon drains the abscess by placing a tube through the abdominal wall into the abscess. The tube is left in place for about two weeks, and antibiotics are prescribed to clear the infection.

  Once the infection is clear, the appendix can be removed surgically. In some people, the abscess is drained, and the appendix is removed immediately.

By Mayo Clinic Staff

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Diagnosis & treatment

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